

Color Clash — UI/UX Design Document

Rebuild v2.0 • Mobile-first React PWA

Dhoola • Geeks for Games

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1. Document control

Field	Value
Document	UI/UX Design Document
Product	Color Clash
Release	v2.0 — "Rebuild"
Status	Draft for approval
Depends on	PRD v2.0, TRD v2.0
Supersedes	MASTER_BLUEPRINT.md \$9 and \$12, BRANDING.md \$visual (v1.0)

1.1 Scope

Design system, screen inventory, flows, table layout, motion, audio, haptics, accessibility, states and responsive rules. It does not specify implementation or network behaviour.

1.2 Design principles

1. **The table answers four questions without being asked.** Whose turn is it? What is the active colour? Which of my cards can I play? What just happened?
2. **Colour is never the only signal.** Every colour has a name and a glyph. A player who cannot distinguish red from green plays exactly the same game.
3. **One-handed, portrait, on a phone, on a train.** Everything reachable with a thumb. Landscape and desktop are adaptations of that, not the other way round.
4. **Motion explains causation.** An animation exists to show that *this* card caused *that* effect. Decorative motion that explains nothing is cut.

5. **Never punish a wrong tap.** An illegal card dims and explains itself. It does not shake, buzz, flash red, or cost anything.
6. **The interface is never a rules engine.** If the UI needs to know a rule to render, the rule is missing from the view model.

2. Brand and visual identity

Carried forward from v1.0's completed rebrand (RF-014). The mark is a **four-shard prism** — four coloured triangles meeting at a point around a gold core. Every asset derives from that one shape rule: shards, chevrons, and a consistent **12-degree shear** through the set. The declaration call is **"CLASH!"**, shouted at one card.

2.1 Brand palette

Defined once in `tools/gen-brand.ts`, mirrored as CSS custom properties and by `COLOR_HEX` in `@colorclash/game-content`. The four shard colours are deliberately off the primary hues, so the brand does not read as a generic primary-colour card game.

Token	Hex	Role
--shard-1	#e2483f	Brand red
--shard-2	#f2b134	Brand amber
--shard-3	#2f9e5e	Brand green
--shard-4	#2f7fd4	Brand blue
--ink	#070f20	Background, native splash
--gold	#f0b840	Focus, highlight, "your turn", legal glow

2.2 Gameplay colour palette

These are **game state**, not brand. Every pairing below has been validated against WCAG AA and is asserted by a test that fails the build.

Colour	Hex	Ink	Label	Glyph context
RED	#d8332f	#ffffff	"Red"	Classic, Mayhem, Freestyle
YELLOW	#f0a81c	#10151f	"Yellow"	"
GREEN	#3f9e2e	#10151f	"Green"	"
BLUE	#1f6fc4	#ffffff	"Blue"	"
PINK	#e4478f	#10151f	"Pink"	Flipstorm, light side
TEAL	#17a9a0	#10151f	"Teal"	"
PURPLE	#7a3fc0	#ffffff	"Purple"	"
ORANGE	#e8752a	#10151f	"Orange"	"
DARK_PINK	#8e1c53	#ffffff	"Dark Pink"	Flipstorm, dark side
DARK_TEAL	#0c6560	#ffffff	"Dark Teal"	"
DARK_PURPLE	#4a2076	#ffffff	"Dark Purple"	"
DARK_ORANGE	#8f4212	#ffffff	"Dark Orange"	"

Design rule: ink is whichever of white or #10151f has the better contrast against its swatch. This table exists because the obvious choice — white on the brand colour throughout — fails: white on YELLOW is 2.03:1, worse than the 2.93:1 it was meant to improve on.

2.3 Mode accents

Mode	Accent	Deep
Classic Clash	#c2312c	#6d1512
Flipstorm	#7a3fc0	#361a5c

Mode	Accent	Deep
Mayhem	#b4620d	#4d2603
Wild Rush	#1f6fc4	#0d2f57
Freestyle	#2c7a2c	#123d12

2.4 Table themes

ocean (default) · midnight · ember, plus unlockable cosmetic themes and a **high contrast** theme that is always available and is not a cosmetic unlock. A theme changes felt texture, rail colour and ambient tint only. **A theme may never change a card face colour, a glyph, or any element that carries game state.**

2.5 Typography

Role	Family	Fallback	Usage
Display	Nunito	system rounded sans	Headings, mode names, banners, card numbers
Body	Barlow	system sans	UI labels, rules text, logs, standings

Both under SIL OFL 1.1. Numerals are tabular in every context where they line up (standings, timers, counts).

Step	Size / line-height	Use
Display L	34 / 40	Screen titles, result banner
Display M	26 / 32	Mode tile names, section heads
Title	20 / 26	Sheet titles, seat names
Body	16 / 24	Default
Small	14 / 20	Secondary metadata
Caption	12 / 16	Timestamps, log lines

Minimum body size on the table is 14px. A “larger text” setting scales the whole type ramp by 1.15× and 1.30× without reflowing the table layout.

2.6 Spacing, radius, elevation

4px base grid. Spacing tokens: 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48. Radius: cards 12px, tiles 16px, sheets 20px (top corners only), chips 999px. Elevation is expressed as three shadow tokens only — raised, floating, overlay — plus the gold glow used exclusively for legality and focus.

3. Card design

3.1 Construction

A card face carries **no bitmap art**. It is one element with:

1. One face colour from the palette.
2. One shard motif on the identity’s 12-degree diagonal.
3. One text glyph.

This is a performance decision (no image decode on a table with up to 60 visible cards) and an accessibility decision (the glyph is real text, so it scales, inverts and is readable by a screen reader).

3.2 Glyph vocabulary

Kind	Glyph	Kind	Glyph
Number	0–9	Draw Four	+4
Skip	⌀	Draw Five	+5
Reverse	≠	Skip Everyone	⌀⌀
Draw Two	+2	Wild Draw Color	+?
Wild	★	Discard All	⋈
Wild Draw Four	+4	Wild Draw Six	+6
Flip	⌘	Wild Draw Ten	+10
Draw One	+1	Wild Reverse Skip	≠⌀

A wild card shows the four-shard prism in place of a single face colour, so “this card is not tied to a colour” is legible at a glance and at thumbnail size.

3.3 Card states

State	Treatment
Legal	Full opacity, gold rim glow, lifts 8px on press
Illegal	55% opacity, no glow, no lift, still fully readable
Selected	Lifted 16px, scaled 1.06, gold rim intensified
In flight	Travelling to the discard pile
Flex-eligible (Freestyle only)	Secondary triangle indicator becomes prominent; a long-press opens the flex affordance
Face-down	Card back — a cosmetic slot; always the same back for all opponents in a match

Every card carries an `aria-label` of the form “Red 7, playable” or “Wild Draw Four, not playable”.

3.4 Freestyle secondary matrix

A Freestyle coloured card shows its primary identity at full size and its secondary colour/action as a small triangle in the lower-right corner. When the flex token is available and the secondary would make an otherwise-illegal card legal, the triangle pulses gently and a long-press opens a two-option confirm: “Play as Red 7” / “Flex → Green 7 (uses your Flex Power)”.

4. Screen inventory

Fifteen screens. Each has a real URL, so a deep link, a back button and a refresh all behave.

#	Screen	Route	Purpose
1	Splash / Loading	/	Boot, asset prefetch, session restore
2	Name prompt	/welcome	First run only — one field
3	Home	/home	Quick Play, Quick Match, Modes, Online, Resume, Profile, Store
4	Mode select	/modes	Five mode tiles with complexity and “Learn rules”
5	Rules sheet	overlay	Per-ruleset rules, reachable from three places
6	Local lobby	/lobby	Seats, bot tiers, match settings, Start
7	Online home	/online	Create room · Join by code · Quick Match queue

#	Screen	Route	Purpose
8	Online lobby	/room/:code	Seats, ready, host controls, share link
9	Matchmaking	/queue/:mode	Queue status, estimated wait, cancel
10	Table	/play	The match
11	Choice modal	overlay	Colour · target · swap · flex · draw-colour
12	Pause sheet	overlay	Sound, motion, rules, leave
13	Result	/result	Winner, banked points, cards held, rematch
14	Profile & stats	/profile	Identity, stats, history, achievements, sign-in
15	Store	/store	Cosmetics, currencies, season track

5. Core flows

5.1 First run

Launch → Splash (prefetch; ends when prefetch ends, 400 ms floor, 1500 ms backstop)
 → Name prompt [one field, 16 chars, Continue]
 → Home
 → "Quick Play" [no configuration at all]
 → Table, Classic Clash, 3 bots

Target: playable table in under 20 seconds. The name prompt is the only gate, and it exists because the alternative — everyone called "PlayerOne" — was a real v1.0 problem. Sign-in is *not* on this path.

5.2 Private room (the acquisition flow)

Home → Online → Create room
 → Online lobby: 5-char code, Share button (copies colorclash.app/r/ABCDE)
 → Friends open the link → land directly in the lobby
 → Host sets ruleset + settings; empty seats filled with bots at chosen tier
 → All humans "I'm ready" → Host: Start
 → Table

The share affordance is one tap and copies a **link**, not a code, because a code in a group chat is a thing to retype and a link is a thing to tap.

5.3 Quick Match

Home → Quick Match → pick ruleset → Queue
 → Queue screen: "Finding players...", elapsed, estimated wait, Cancel
 → Seated within 15 s → brief "Match found" with seat reveal → Table
 → If 30 s elapses: seat against bots, and say so plainly:
 "Filling the table with bots so you don't wait."

Honesty at the 30-second boundary is a design requirement. Silently seating a player against bots and letting them find out is the single fastest way to lose Sam (persona P4).

5.4 A turn

Turn arrives → turn chip lights gold, seat pulses once, optional haptic
 → legal cards glow; illegal cards dim

- tap a card → lift + highlight
- tap again (or drag to pile) → card flies to discard (260 ms)
- effect resolves → banner if it is a notable effect
- if a choice is required → focused modal
- turn passes; direction arrow animates if reversed

Tap-tap is the primary interaction; drag is a supported alternative. Drag-only would fail one-handed portrait use at the bottom of a phone.

5.5 The Clash call

Hand goes 2 → 1

- CLASH button appears bottom-right, gold, with a 4 s shrinking ring
- Tap → "CLASH!" banner, ring dismissed
- Miss it → next game action settles it → 2 cards drawn, penalty banner

The ring is the grace window made visible. It is not a countdown to a consequence the player cannot see coming.

5.6 Disconnection

Socket drops → "Reconnecting..." strip above the table, table stays interactive-looking but inputs queue
 → reconnect → snapshot + missed events → hard cut if too far behind, otherwise fast-forward at 3× cadence

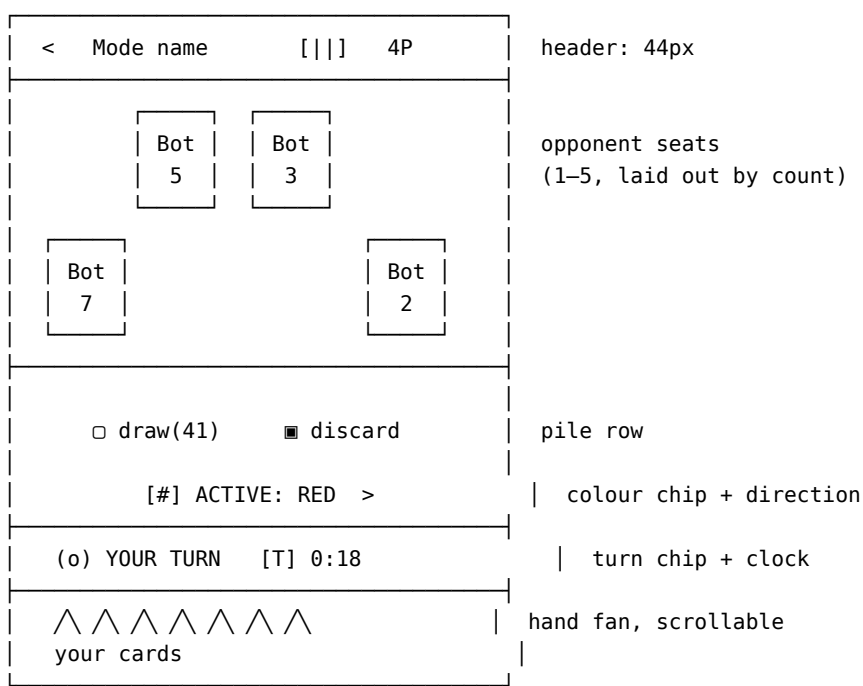
- strip clears

Room dies → "This match has ended" → Result or Home, never a blank screen

6. The table

The table is the screen that matters. Everything else is navigation.

6.1 Portrait layout (primary)



| (:) emote (*) CLASH! | action rail: 56px

Fixed rules:

- The hand is **always** the bottom band and is never obscured by an overlay other than a choice modal.
- The pile row is vertically centred in the remaining space so it does not move when the opponent count changes.
- The active colour is a **chip with a text label**, not a coloured dot.
- The turn clock renders **inside** the turn chip, not in the header — a v1.0 correction, because a header clock in landscape sat too far from where the player was looking.

6.2 Opponent seat layouts by count

Opponents	Arrangement
1	One seat, top centre
2	Two seats, top left and top right
3	Top centre, upper-left, upper-right
4	Two top, two flanking
5	Two top, two flanking, one overflow chip row

A seat shows: avatar, name (truncated to 10 characters + ellipsis), hand count as a numeral, a bot badge if a bot, a connection badge if disconnected, a “called CLASH” indicator, and the turn glow when active.

6.3 Landscape

The pile row moves to centre-left; the hand fan becomes a wider single row along the bottom; opponent seats arc across the top. **The direction arrow moves into the turn chip** and the header collapses to a single overflow button. The constraint that produced this layout: in v1.0’s landscape, a seat overlapped the discard pile and the hand bar sat below the fold.

6.4 Desktop

Maximum content width 1100px, centred, with the table filling the viewport height. Cards spread rather than fan. Keyboard support: ←/→ to move card focus, Enter to play, D to draw, Space to Clash, Esc for the pause sheet.

6.5 Hand rendering

- 1–7 cards: full fan, all visible, no scroll.
- 8–14 cards: compressed fan with 40% overlap.
- 15+: horizontally scrollable strip with edge fades and a “N cards” count. **Legal cards sort to the front of the strip** so the player never has to scroll to find a move.
- Reordering by drag is supported and persists for the match.

7. Choice modals

A choice **pauses progression**. The active player must not be able to accidentally play another card underneath it.

Choice	Presentation
Colour	Four (or the version’s) large swatches, each with its text name and a shard motif. Arranged 2×2 for thumb reach.
Target	The eligible seats rendered as tappable cards with name and hand count. Ineligible seats are visibly excluded, not merely unresponsive.
Swap hand (Mayhem 7)	Same as target, with your own hand count shown alongside for comparison.

Choice	Presentation
Draw colour (Flipstorm) Flex (Freestyle)	Colour swatches with a warning line: “They draw until they match.” Two labelled options: primary vs flex, with the cost stated — “uses your Flex Power”.

Rules for all of them:

- Backdrop scrim at 60%, table still faintly visible so context is not lost.
- No dismiss-by-tapping-outside. A choice has no null answer.
- If the turn clock expires, the server answers with the first eligible option and the modal closes with a brief “Auto-selected” note, so the player knows what happened.
- Focus is trapped; the first option is focused on open.

8. Feedback system

8.1 Banners

A banner is a short centre-screen strip for a notable effect. Duration scales with the pacing cadence (600–900 ms).

Event	Banner
Skip	“SKIPPED — {name} loses a turn”
Reverse	“REVERSED” + direction arrow animation
Draw penalty	“{name} draws {n}”
Stack grows	“+{n} — stack now {total}”
Flip	“FLIPSTORM — {Light Dark} side” + full table theme transition
Skip Everyone	“SKIP EVERYONE — {name} plays again”
Discard All	“DISCARD ALL — {n} {colour} cards gone”
Hands rotated	“ALL HANDS ROTATE” + arrow sweep
Hands swapped	“{a} ≠ {b}”
Elimination	“{name} ELIMINATED — 25 cards”
Clash called	“CLASH!”
Clash missed	“MISSED — {name} draws 2”
Flex used	“FLEX POWER SPENT”

Banners **queue**; they never overlap, and they never block input.

8.2 The event log

A collapsible strip of the last 6 lines above the hand, each one sentence in plain language, timestamped, and mirrored into an aria-live=“polite” region. Expanding it shows the full round. Every line has an icon so the log is scannable without reading.

8.3 Illegal move feedback

Tapping an illegal card shows a small anchored tooltip with the reason, in words:

Reason code	Player-facing text
NOT_YOUR_TURN	“Wait for your turn”
NOT_YOUR_CARD	“That isn’t your card”
MUST_ANSWER_PENALTY	“Play a +{n} or higher, or draw”
NO_MATCH	“Match the colour, the number, or play a wild”
CHOICE_PENDING	“Finish your choice first”
FLEX_UNAVAILABLE	“Your Flex Power is spent”
ELIMINATED	“You’re out of this round”

No shake, no red flash, no sound, no cost. A raw reason code must never reach a player.

8.4 Audio

Every cue is synthesised at play time from WebAudio oscillators plus a generated noise buffer. **Zero audio files ship.**

Cue	Character
Card play	Short percussive click, pitched by card colour
Card draw	Softer, lower, with a brush of noise
Penalty draw	Descending three-note figure, one note per card up to three
Clash call	Bright rising two-note stab
Flip	Filtered sweep, direction matching the side change
Elimination	Low descending tone
Turn arrives (yours)	Single soft bell
Victory	Short ascending arpeggio

“Sound off” means no audio node is created — not a muted node. One sound preference, reflected in every switch that exposes it (lobby, pause sheet, settings), kept in sync through a subscription rather than duplicated state. The AudioContext resumes if suspended and is recreated if closed, on the next cue.

8.5 Haptics

Android only, via Capacitor. Off by default; on is a single toggle.

Moment	Pattern
Your turn begins	Light tap
Card played	Selection tick
Penalty landed on you	Medium double
Clash window opens	Light double
Match won	Success pattern

Never during another player’s turn, never repeated within 300 ms.

9. Motion

9.1 Budgets

Class	Duration	Easing
Micro-interaction (press, toggle, chip)	120–200 ms	ease-out
Card flight	260 ms	cubic-bezier(.2,.8,.2,1)
Turn change / seat glow	200 ms	ease-in-out
Banner in/out	180 ms in, 240 ms out	ease-out / ease-in
Major reveal (round result, flip transition)	400–600 ms	cubic-bezier(.16,1,.3,1)
Screen transition	240 ms	shared-axis

Nothing blocks input. A player may tap the next card while the previous one is still in flight; the command is queued, not dropped.

9.2 Event pacing

Events arrive in batches. They are presented on a queue at a **600–900 ms cadence**, so a chain of effects reads as a sequence rather than a jump. Hand counts tick down one seat at a time.

Pacing is presentation only. It can never change which commands are accepted or in what order.

9.3 Reduced motion

Honours the OS setting; the in-app toggle **overrides** it in both directions.

When reduced motion is on: card flight becomes an instant cut with a 120 ms cross-fade; banners appear without slide; the flip transition is a single cross-fade rather than a sweep; confetti is replaced by a static burst; seat glows change opacity rather than scale; pacing tightens to 200 ms.

Reduced motion never removes information. Every banner, log line and glyph that appears in full-motion mode also appears in reduced-motion mode.

10. Accessibility

ID	Requirement
A11Y-01	Colour is never the only carrier of state. Card identity is colour and glyph and label; active colour is a named chip; legality is a glow and an opacity difference and an aria-label.
A11Y-02	Every colour/ink pairing clears WCAG AA, asserted by a test that fails the build.
A11Y-03	Touch targets on the table are $\geq 44 \times 44$ CSS px. Cards in a compressed fan have an extended hit area beyond their visible bounds.
A11Y-04	Focus-visible outlines on every interactive element, in gold, at 2px, never removed.
A11Y-05	The event log is an aria-live="polite" region. Turn changes and choice requests are announced.
A11Y-06	Choice modals trap focus and are dismissible only by answering.
A11Y-07	"Larger text" scales the ramp 1.15× / 1.30× without breaking the table layout.
A11Y-08	A high contrast table theme is always available and is never a cosmetic unlock.
A11Y-09	Left-handed layout mirrors the action rail: the CLASH button and primary actions move to the left edge.
A11Y-10	No content flashes more than three times per second.
A11Y-11	The full game is playable with a keyboard on desktop.
A11Y-12	Text is never rendered into an image.

11. States: empty, loading, error, offline

Every screen specifies all four. A blank screen is a defect.

Context	Empty	Loading	Error	Offline
Home / Resume	Resume tile hidden entirely	—	—	Online tiles dim with "Offline — play vs bots"
Online lobby	"Waiting for players" + Add bot CTA	Skeleton seats	"Couldn't reach the room" + Retry	"You're offline" + Retry
Matchmaking	—	"Finding players..." + elapsed	"Queue unavailable" + Play vs bots	Queue disabled with reason
Table	—	Deal animation, never a spinner	"Reconnecting..." strip	Same strip; local play unaffected
Match history	"No matches yet — play one"	Skeleton rows	"Couldn't load history" + Retry	Cached last-known + "Showing saved"
Store	"Nothing here yet"	Skeleton tiles	"Store unavailable"	Disabled with reason
Leaderboard	"No ranked matches yet"	Skeleton rows	Retry	Cached + stale marker

Error copy rule: say what happened, then what the player can do. Never show a code, a stack, or the word “error” alone.

12. Onboarding

12.1 Progressive, not front-loaded

No tutorial stands between first launch and first play. Learning is delivered in three layers:

1. **The table teaches itself.** Legal cards glow. Illegal taps explain. The log narrates.
2. **First-time hints** — one per distinctive mechanic, shown the first time it is encountered, dismissible forever:
 - *Flipstorm*: “The whole deck just flipped. New colours, new rules.”
 - *Mayhem*: “You can stack a +2 on a +2 — or draw the whole pile.”
 - *Mayhem*: “25 cards and you’re out. Watch the stack.”
 - *Wild Rush*: “Every card is wild. Pick who suffers.”
 - *Freestyle*: “One Flex Power per round. Spend it well.”
 - *Any mode*: “Down to one card — hit CLASH before anyone moves.”
3. **Rules sheets** — per ruleset, reachable from the mode tile, the lobby and the pause sheet. Short, card-illustrated, and they **name the rule flag** wherever a default was chosen rather than specified, so a project decision is never presented to a player as a law of the game.

12.2 Optional tutorial

A 90-second scripted Classic Clash match with a fixed deck, replayable from the rules sheet. It teaches exactly four things: match by colour or number, wilds, draw when stuck, call CLASH.

13. Result and progression screens

13.1 Result

Three-tone presentation. A win gets confetti and a crown; a loss gets neither.

The screen leads with the two underlying facts, in this order:

1. **What the winner banked** — the point value of every card still held by everyone else.
2. **How many cards each player was caught with**, and what those were worth.

Cumulative match total is a **sub-line**, not the headline, and is only shown when the win condition actually chains rounds. A loser’s line reads “12 left in hand”, never “-12” — the first is a fact, the second reads as a punishment for a game people play to relax.

Actions: **Play again** (keeps the table: same seats, same ruleset, new seed) · **Home**. Rewards earned appear as a small animated row, and every value shown is the server’s, never the client’s.

13.2 Profile and stats

Identity block (avatar, name, level, rank tier if ranked), then per-ruleset stats, then the last 50 matches, then achievements. A guest account shows a persistent, non-nagging “Sign in to keep this on every device” affordance — shown once per session at most.

13.3 Store

Grid of cosmetic tiles with a clear price in the correct currency, a preview that renders the item **in situ** (a card back is shown on an actual card; a table theme is shown on an actual table), and an owned state. Currency balance is always visible in the header. No countdown timers designed to pressure, and no randomised paid rewards of any kind.

14. Responsive rules

Breakpoint	Width	Behaviour
Phone portrait	< 480px	Primary layout. Single column. Hand fan scrollable.
Phone landscape	< 900px, height < 480px	Pile centre-left, wide hand row, arrow in turn chip, collapsed header
Tablet	480–1024px	Portrait layout, larger cards, wider seat arc
Desktop	> 1024px	Max 1100px content, spread hand, keyboard shortcuts

The three e2e viewports — phone portrait, phone landscape, desktop — are a test requirement, not a nicety. Every shipped layout bug in v1.0 was size-dependent.

Additional rules: respect safe-area insets on notched devices; never place an interactive element within 8px of a screen edge except a deliberately edge-anchored rail; and no layout may require a horizontal page scroll.

15. Content and copy

Voice: direct, warm, short. Never cute at the expense of clarity.

Do	Don't
"Match the colour, the number, or play a wild"	"Invalid move"
"Filling the table with bots so you don't wait"	(silence)
"12 left in hand"	"-12"
"They draw until they match"	"Wild Draw Color effect applied"
"Down to one card — hit CLASH"	"UNO state pending"
"Couldn't reach the room. Try again?"	"Error 1006"

All player-facing strings are externalised into a message catalogue from day one, so localisation is a content task rather than an engineering one — even though v2.0 ships English only.

16. Design deliverables

Deliverable	Format
Component library	Figma, with tokens matching the CSS custom property names exactly
Screen designs	All 15 screens × 3 breakpoints
Table layout variants	Opponent counts 1–5, portrait and landscape
Motion specification	Prototype or annotated video for card flight, flip transition, result reveal

Deliverable	Format
Icon set	Existing generated set, extended for new screens, same shard-and-shear rule
Copy deck	Every string, keyed to the message catalogue
Accessibility annotations	Focus order, roles, labels, live regions, per screen

17. Open design questions

#	Question
D1	Does the hand fan scroll horizontally or reflow to two rows above 15 cards? Needs a usability test on a 5-inch device during a Mayhem stack.
D2	Is the drag-to-play gesture worth its complexity given tap-tap works, or does it only serve desktop?
D3	How prominent should the bot badge be? Too subtle is dishonest; too loud makes a backfilled table feel like a consolation prize.
D4	Should the turn clock be visible at all in casual Quick Match, or only in ranked?
D5	Does the Flipstorm side change deserve a full-screen transition, or is a table-wide colour sweep enough at the 600 ms budget?